



Emergency Resource Guide

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- Chicago Low Income Trust Fund
- Legal Aid
- SNAP/ Link/ Medicaid
- Chicago Furniture Bank
- English as a Second Language (ESL)/ GED
- Employment
- Rental Assistance
- Medicaid Transportation



ACCESSING EMERGENCY SHELTER

EHARC (Emergency Homeless Assessment and Response Center)

- Call 3-1-1 (312-744-5000) to request placement in a shelter. Have your household names and size ready. Remember to record the request # provided by the operator.
- You may be asked to wait several hours or days before being placed in a shelter.
- You can wait overnight while your request is processed by the city at the police dept., hospital, or the SPARC center (2241 S. Halsted)

Shelter Placement

- Upon referral through 311, a family is placed in a shelter with available beds based on need.
- Interim shelters are open 24 hours. Youth, families and individuals may stay up to 12 hours. Youth, families and individuals may stay up to 120 days in an interim shelter.



COORDINATED ENTRY SYSTEM (CES)

City-wide list that serves as a front door to connect individuals and families facing homelessness to long-term housing and support.

Eligibility:

Families that are living in a shelter, public place, or outside or fleeing domestic violence.

Youth (14-24) that are living in a shelter, outside, or doubled up or fleeing domestic violence.

Access

Text 773-786-9916

Call 312-361-1707

Visit www.csh.org/chicagoces for a list of CES assessment appointments and locations.



FREE BIRTH CERTIFICATES AND STATE IDS

Individuals experiencing homelessness are eligible for free birth certificates and state IDs.

Eligibility

Individuals living doubled-up, in shelter, or outside.

Access

Request a homeless verification letter from your case manager or STLS liaison.

Tip: Call the Chicago Coalition to end Homelessness Law Project at 1-800-940-1119 for assistance.

Tip: To avoid going through 311, you can also search for low threshold or emergency shelters that offer nightly beds (Franciscan, Ujima, The Crib, etc.)



CHICAGO HOUSING AUTHORITY (CHA)

Permanent housing funded by the local and federal government. Rent is subsidized and much cheaper than normal “market-rate” rent. Housing is provided either as a voucher or as placement in CHA-managed housing. Wait list for units can range from 6 months-20 years.

Eligibility

Certain criminal offenses will disqualify participants. Participants must be citizens OR meet immigrant status requirements. Must meet income guidelines.

Access

Apply for the site-based wait list at applyonline.thecha.org. For better success chances, pick a wait list with the shortest estimated amount of time (ex: 6-12 months).

Tip: Apply for both the Project-Based Voucher (PBV) and Public Housing (PH) programs. Check the eligibility requirements for each site (senior, disabled, etc.) to avoid disqualification.



CHICAGO LOW INCOME TRUST FUND

Voucher program that matches individuals to low-income housing. The program is city funded, but units are managed by private landlords or non-profits.

Eligibility

Individuals falling below certain income levels.

Access

Review the list of 600 properties included in the trust fund. Call each management group directly to ask for vacancy and the application. View the list of properties at <https://www.chicago.gov/city/en/depts/doh/provdrs/renters/svc/s/affordable-rental-housing-resource-list.html>

You may also be matched through the CES system, although matches are rare.



LEGAL AID ORGANIZATIONS

Both Legal Aid Chicago and Law Center for Better Housing offer legal support for housing issues, such as eviction and housing discrimination.

Legal Aid Chicago can be reached by phone at (312) 341-1070 or applying online for housing legal advocacy.

Tip: The intake line accepts calls weekdays beginning at 8 am. Legal Aid Chicago takes a limited number of calls each day, so it is best to call early.

Lawyers' Committee for Better Housing can be reached at (312) 347-7600.



SNAP/LINK, TANF, Medicaid, and WIC Benefit

Public benefits are grants to assist families with necessities such as food, clothing, and other household goods. Medicaid offers no-cost health insurance.

Eligibility

New SNAP Work Requirements

Before the federal budget bill, Able-Bodied Adults Without Dependents (ABAWDs) applied to adults ages 18-54 who had:

- No kids under 18 living at home
- No disabilities

Now, more people must meet or be exempt from work requirements, like:

- People, with no disabilities, ages 55-64
- People with kids at home who are only 14 or older.
- People who are homeless
- Veterans

Access

Apply online at

www.abe.illinois.gov

If you are a current SNAP participant and need immediate food assistance:

- Call 2-1-1
- Use the Greater Chicago Food Depository and its Partners or dial (773) 247-3663 to find a food pantry or food distribution site near you.



CHICAGO FURNITURE BANK

The Chicago Furniture Bank allows a household to pick a home's worth of furniture from their warehouse for a low fee.

Eligibility

Individuals or households that are transitioning from homelessness to permanent housing.

Access

There is a \$100 fee for the furniture package. Contact CCH at 312-641-4140 for a referral to the furniture bank.

Tip: Call the CCH Law Project at 1-800-940-1119 for assistance with SNAP application process or loss of benefits.



FREE ESL AND GED/HiSET COURSES

Learn English (ESL) or complete your high school education (GED/HiSET) FOR FREE. Any level of learner accepted, from beginner to advanced.

- ESL classes cover reading, writing, listening, speaking, grammar, and vocabulary skills. We also have Citizenship.
- High School Equivalency classes cover Language Arts, Math, Social Studies and Science to prepare you to take the GED/HiSET
- We also offer programs to help you transition into college credit or job credential programs.

Eligibility

- Be 18 years or older (or provide proof of high school separation)
- Live in Illinois
- F-1, F-2, J-1, J-2 visas not accepted.

Access

Apply online or in-person at any of the 6 city college locations.

www.ccc.edu/site/adult-education

EMPLOYMENT



GreenCorp Chicago

- Green job training and landscaping training
- Offers 7-9 months of employment with on-job training
- Graduates have found work in companies like Cardno, Christy Webber, Safety Kleen and AES

<https://greencorpschicago.org/>



Safer Foundation

- Employment resources for returning citizens
- Offers job placement support, training + education, and reentry support + wellness programs

<https://saferfoundation.org/>



Growing Home

- Englewood-based farming program
- Offers 25 hrs/wk of paid on-the-job experience and training, a 12 wk employment training program, and an 8 wk IT-training program

<https://www.growinghomeinc.org/>



Greater West Town Community Development project

- Offers woodworking, shipping, and receiving vocational training
- Job placement support
- West Town Academy (an alternative high school for students between the ages of 16 and 21 not enrolled in a traditional high school or GED program who wish to return to school and obtain a high school diploma)

<https://gwtp.org/>



UNITEHERE! Culinary Hospitality Institute (UHCHI)

- Provides culinary training for an in-demand career in hotels, banquet halls, restaurants and sports centers around Chicago.
- Prepares you for a career as a Chef de Partie and supports you as you take the first steps on this great career

<https://hire360chicago.com/unite-here/>





Downtown Campus

237 S. Desplaines Street
Chicago, IL 60661
(312) 798-3300

Cleonslate

6027 S. Wentworth Ave.
Chicago, IL 60621
(312) 226-6361

EMPLOYMENT

Jump Start Your Career

Cara is not your traditional workforce development program. We get that one size does not fit all and have built a platform that gives you what you need – new skills, new confidence, or new resources to help you on a path to gainful employment. We do this in a way that deepens connections within networks and within communities so that the next time life throws you a curveball, you'll have a community who'll be there for you to help you bounce right back.



Why Cara

Cara provides access to a network of more than 50 employment partners in numerous industries – all searching for talent just like you. We offer training and certification courses covering foundational job skills, digital and financial literacy, and industry certifications like OSHA, food service, and commercial cleaning. And we also offer complimentary resources while on your job search, including transportation passes, professional clothing, and other supportive services.

[LEARN MORE](#)

How to Join



1. CONTACT US

If you're interested in joining Cara, fill out our [Job Seekers application form](#) and let us know how to reach you.



2. PHONE CONVERSATION

A recruitment team member will call to learn more about your interest, experience, current situation, and hope for the future.



3. INTAKE APPOINTMENT AND TOUR

Come to one of our campuses for a tour and a new participant intake appointment.



4. DOCUMENTS

When you come in person, you are required to bring 2 forms of ID – a **valid state-issued ID and social security card.**



5. WELCOME

We will invite you to join our program, where you'll begin your Cara journey!

EMERGENCY RENTAL ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS

DFSS Emergency Rental Assistance One-time assistance towards rent or rent arrears.

Are You Eligible for the Rental Assistance Program?

The Rental Assistance Program (RAP) provides funding to Chicagoans who are at risk of becoming homeless. RAP helps Chicagoans who have housing right now, but who may become homeless soon because they lost income or had another eligible emergency that prevents them from paying rent.

Assistance May Include

- Payment of future rent, or rental arrears (past-due rent), to prevent eviction
- Security deposits in cases of fire, flood, foreclosure, domestic violence, or eviction

You May Be Eligible If

- You live in the City of Chicago
- You are at risk of becoming homeless due to eviction, loss of income, or another emergency
- Your household income is at or below [30% of Area Median Income \(AMI\)](#), as defined by the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD)
- You can demonstrate the ability to sustain housing after assistance is provided
- Your landlord completes the RAP requirements

What Will Happen After You Apply

If your application is selected, a case manager will call or email you to make sure your application is complete. They may ask you to submit additional documents. An in-person, video, or photo inspection of your rental unit is then required to make sure the unit meets federal standards.

For help with your application, or to apply in person, call or visit any of the City of Chicago Community Service Centers listed above. Community Service Centers are open Monday-Friday between 9 am and 5 pm.

▼ Community Service Center Locations

Auburn Gresham Community Service Center

1140 West 79th Street, Chicago, IL 60620
312.747.0200
Monday-Friday, 9 am to 5 pm

North Area Community Service Center

845 West Wilson Avenue, Chicago, IL 60640
312.744.2580
Monday-Friday, 9 am to 5 pm

Garfield Community Service Center

10 South Kedzie Avenue, Chicago, IL 60612
312.746.5400
Monday-Friday, 9 am to 5 pm

South Chicago Community Service Center

8650 South Commercial Avenue, Chicago, IL 60617
312.747.0500
Monday-Friday, 9 am to 5 pm

Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. Community Service Center

4314 South Cottage Grove, Chicago, IL 60653
312.747.2300
Monday-Friday, 9 am to 5 pm

Trina Davila Community Service Center

4312 West North Avenue, Chicago, IL 60639
312.744.2014
Monday-Friday, 9 am to 5 pm

MEDICAID TRANSPORTATION



Trip Request Instructions

You or the person calling for you will need to:

1.  **Call a transportation company to see if they can take you to your doctor's appointment.**
 - You can call the transportation company you always use (or)
 - If you need help finding a transportation company you can call First Transit at **1-877-725-0569**.
2.  **Call First Transit at 1-877-725-0569 to get your trip approved.**

First Transit will ask:

- Your name
- May need to get your "OK" to talk with the person calling for you
- Your pick-up address and phone number
- Your Medicaid ID# (9 digit recipient identification number)
- The general reason for your doctor's visit
- The name of the office/clinic /hospital where you are going
- The name of the doctor you will be seeing
- The address and phone number where you are going
- The appointment date and time
- If there are medical or non-medical reasons why you can not use public or other transportation
- If you use a walker, wheelchair, or cane
- If you can travel by yourself

**** First Transit will give you a reference number ****

3.  **Call the transportation company and give them your reference number and schedule your pick-up time.**
4.  **Call the transportation company before your doctor's appointment to confirm your reservation.**